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RESEARCH BRIEF

Where Should Restaurants, Suppliers and Field-Service Businesses Automate First?

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Research focus: Operational workflows, business systems and software investment priorities.

Introduction

Not every manual business process needs automation.

For small and medium-sized businesses, the challenge is identifying which activities create enough repeated work, delays or errors to justify investing in technology.

UK government research provides a useful starting point.

The UK Business Data Survey 2026 examines how businesses use digital data, while HMRC research on electronic invoicing highlights the continued use of document-based administrative processes.

Neither study proves that a particular restaurant, supplier or maintenance company has inefficient operations.

However, together they identify useful questions for examining how information moves through a business.

1. Restaurants: connecting operational information

Restaurants may operate separate systems for bookings, payments, food delivery, purchasing, inventory and staff scheduling.

Where these tools do not communicate, managers may need to consolidate information manually.

A useful first investigation is the daily or weekly management report.

Discovery question: How long does it take to combine sales, labour, purchasing and delivery-platform information into a reliable operational report?

Possible intervention: Integrating existing systems into a focused management dashboard.

Success measure: Reporting time saved, improved data accuracy and faster access to operational information.

2. Hospitality suppliers: improving order visibility

Suppliers coordinate customer orders, stock availability, dispatch, delivery and after-sales support.

Where information is scattered across separate tools, staff may need to manually check order progress or respond repeatedly to status enquiries.

Discovery question: Can customer-service staff see the complete status of an order without contacting another department?

Possible intervention: A shared order-status and exception-management system connected to existing platforms.

Success measure: Fewer repeated enquiries, faster exception resolution and reduced administrative handling time.

3. Field operations: reducing administrative handoffs

Maintenance contractors, engineers and other mobile service providers often manage enquiries, quotations, scheduling, site visits, job records and invoicing.

If these stages require repeated manual updates, administrative work can increase as the operation grows.

Discovery question: How many times are customer and job details entered between the first enquiry and final invoice?

Possible intervention: A connected workflow linking enquiry capture, job scheduling, engineer reporting and invoicing.

Success measure: Reduced administration per job, faster invoice preparation and fewer missed follow-ups.

How to decide which workflow deserves investment

Businesses should assess four factors before commissioning software:

Frequency: How often does the process occur?

Impact: What time, cost, error or customer-service problem does it create?

Feasibility: Can existing tools solve the problem through configuration or integration?

Return: Are the expected savings and benefits sufficient to justify the full implementation cost?

A process that occurs once per month may not justify custom development. A process repeated dozens of times each day may warrant closer investigation.

TechWithTop research conclusion

For restaurants, suppliers and field-service businesses, the most valuable software opportunity is not necessarily a new application.

It may be a focused improvement to the way existing systems exchange information.

The correct starting point is to examine the workflow, validate the problem, measure its impact and compare potential solutions.

Technology should follow the operational evidence.

Research methodology: Desk-based analysis of published UK research, with illustrative sector-specific workflow hypotheses. No individual business has been assessed or verified as having these problems.

Sources

Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, *UK Business Data Survey 2026*, published June 2026.
https://www.gov.uk/government/statistics/uk-business-data-survey-2026

HMRC, *Electronic invoicing: SME usage and attitudes*, published March 2026.
https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/electronic-invoicing-sme-usage-and-attitudes